





visiting Tawang's stunning Buddhist monasteries in the northeastern states once only beckoned adventurous travellers who could endure long hours on rough roads and basic accommodation. Luxury travellers stayed away because of poor infrastructure and limited air connectivity. But times have changed; the 'Seven sisters of India' are singing a different tune, as a new dawn breaks across the North East.

The Northeast welcomed its first international five-star branded hotel, Radisson Blu in Guwahati only in 2014. Now deluxe accommodation, which includes high-end hospitality brands, is expected to more than double in just five years to cater to the growing footprint of affluent travellers. "It will rise from 3,674 keys as of March 2026 to nearly 9,266 keys by 2030, led by Assam, followed by Arunachal Pradesh, Meghalaya, Sikkim, Tripura and Nagaland," says Datta of HVS Anarock.

Each destination has its own charm. Some prefer the slow rhythm of Assam's emerald tea plantations and a river cruise on the Brahmaputra, others head for wildlife encounters at Kaziranga National Park or to Sikkim and Arunachal Pradesh for its stunning Buddhist monasteries. Younger travellers want to experience the region's vibrant festival culture, whether it is the tribal spectacle of Nagaland's Hornbill Festival, Meghalaya's Cherry Blossom Festival or Arunachal Pradesh's Ziro Music Festival. Hosting iconic international performers such as Bryan Adams in 2024 and Ed Sheeran in 2025, Shillong has emerged as one of India's most sought-after concert destinations.

Polo Hotels and Resorts, a major local player in the region, plans to open more hotels in the near future. Deval Tibrewalla, Director and CEO of Hotel Polo Towers Group says high-end travellers want a taste of all things local, from cuisine to culture. "They want local experiences and something outdoors so we cater to that demand. We have a seven-course meal paired with seven Meghalayan wines, for instance." The rooms at Polo Resort in Cherrapunji are priced at around ₹14,500 (plus taxes) per night.

It isn't just local hotel groups that are turning the spotlight on the region. IHCL is among the biggest players with 21 hotels across the region, including 12 currently under development. The Leela Palaces, Hotels and Resorts plans to step in with the opening of The Leela Sikkim in 2028.

"Sikkim is particularly compelling because it brings together culture, heritage, Himalayan landscapes, mindfulness, biodiversity and a strong sense of place within a single journey," says Bhatnagar. Chopra of The Postcard Hotel believes the Northeast offers some of the country's most evocative luxury itineraries. "I chose Assam for my first property because of the magnificent tea gardens. Then I realised Kaziranga is just an hour away and the Brahmaputra only 45 minutes, creating a perfect four-day itinerary. My second property is coming up in Pasighat in Arunachal Pradesh." The cost for a room at The Postcard in the Durrung Tea Estate, Assam starts from ₹25,000 per night.

WELLNESS TOURISM IN INDIA IS UNDERGOING A TRANSFORMATION WITH A NEW GENERATION OF TRAVELLERS SEEKING MEASURABLE HEALTH OUTCOMES RATHER THAN SIMPLE RELAXATION

As per MakeMyTrip's data, Assam recorded the highest number of hotel